

Desirable Futures *with robots*



A series of distributed workshops, inventing a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for social robots — reclaiming a question that has, so far, been answered mostly outside HRI.

DOCUMENT

Researcher kit *v1.0*

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desirable-futures-with-robots.org

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I From laboratory to industry.

Robotics is shifting fast. In the past three years, parts of the field — humanoid platforms most visibly, but also home, delivery, service, and care robots — have moved from laboratory subfields to industry-led races: multi-trillion-dollar market forecasts, sizeable state investment in China, South Korea, and elsewhere, and capable, increasingly affordable platforms reaching the market.

Within one to two years, autonomous and semi-autonomous robots — humanoid or otherwise — are expected to be present in everyday life: at home, at work, in care, in public space. We collectively have a narrow window in which to shape the discourse. Practically, the next eighteen to twenty-four months.

II Efficiency. Productivity. Replacement.

The prevailing framing rests on a stable set of arguments: robots will perform jobs that are dull, dirty, or dangerous; offset labour shortages; save human time; and — most visibly through the humanoid wave — represent the next stage of the AI race, a step from text and image into *physical AI*.

*Across these arguments runs a consistent through-line: robots are positioned in **competition with humans** — on labour, on time, on capability.*

The early effects of letting this framing harden are visible in generative AI. With embodied robots — humanoid or otherwise — the same logic extends into domestic, relational, civic, and intimate domains, settings where the criteria of *efficiency* and *replacement* translate poorly.

A softer framing also circulates — companion robots offering emotional support and connection, positioned as answers to loneliness, ageing, and care deficits. Distinct as it appears, it carries the same assumption that human needs can be delegated to machines; as it moves toward the mainstream, its desirability deserves equal scrutiny.

III Reclaiming the narrative.

Without explicit debate, much of robotics has begun to converge on a narrow vision — robots as efficient surrogates for human labour, with the humanoid form as the most visible default. The convergence is largely silent: never formally decided, never ethically justified, sustained by media coverage, capital, and funding incentives.

It deserves to be examined. *Human-centred* design is not the same as *human-shaped* design — and the question is not only how to design a robot, but whether and when a robot is the right answer at all. The robotics community has, at minimum, a responsibility to keep these distinctions live, and, where possible, to **reclaim the narrative**.

This series of workshops is an effort to imagine alternative narratives of our future — and where robots fit in, if at all. We ask:

Can we invent a caring, feminist, *humanist* narrative for robots in our society?

Each workshop opens with a *what if* that reverses one element of the dominant framing — and asks participants to imagine a desirable future growing from there.

Not dystopia. Not subversion for its own sake. A future they would actually want.

Below: the starting bank. Pick one, adapt one, or invent your own. Send new prompts back so the bank grows.

01 What if robots *didn't always say yes* to our orders?

02 What if a robot was *clumsy*, and needed our help — all the time?

03 What if a robot didn't try to *save* your time, but to *waste it well*?

04 What if a robot brought you *something you never asked for*?

ADD YOUR OWN

05

06

07

The rationale needs translation, not simplification. Below: short notes for four common audiences. Adapt to your context, your language, your room. These are starting points, not scripts.

Children

INTRODUCE AS

A storybook framing. *"Imagine a robot who..."* Centre the robot as a character with feelings, quirks, and refusals — not a tool.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Clumsiness. Surprise gifts. A robot that doesn't always say yes. Friendship over function.

WATCH-OUTS

Avoid abstract policy framings. Avoid scary-robot tropes. Keep concrete and playful.

Adolescents

INTRODUCE AS

A speculative-design brief. *"Design the robot you would actually want — for yourself, in five years."*

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Refusal. Identity. Time-wasting (in good ways). Robots that protect rather than monitor.

WATCH-OUTS

Don't moralise. Don't anchor only to school-or-work framings. Make space for ambivalence.

Older adults

INTRODUCE AS

A conversation about everyday life and care, not technology. Start from *what works well now* and ask where a robot might fit — if at all.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Needing-help (from the robot, not toward it). Presence over function. Robots that *aren't* caregivers.

WATCH-OUTS

Avoid framings that read as condescending. The "lonely older person + companion robot" assumption deserves to be opened, not reinforced.

Workers (warehouse, care, service)

INTRODUCE AS

A frank discussion about the workplace they know — what's dignified about it, what's not, where robots are already arriving, and what a desirable shift would look like.

INVERSIONS THAT RESONATE

Co-presence rather than replacement. Robots that hand off rather than take over. Time given back, on the worker's terms.

WATCH-OUTS

Acknowledge precarity directly. Avoid techno-optimism. Be specific about who benefits and who pays in each scenario.

Each workshop should produce at least one *desirable future*, captured on the report form (page 5). Several formats below — pick the one that fits your audience, time, and space. Role-play is recommended: it places people *in* situation rather than reasoning *about* it.

RECOMMENDED Role-play / theatre ~60 min · groups of 3–6 · low-prop, low-cost	STRUCTURE Introduce one <i>what if</i>. Assign roles (a person, the robot, an observer). Play out a five-minute scene. Debrief. Re-play with one element changed.	WHAT TO CAPTURE Title of the scene; who/what/where; the moment of the desirable future; what changed between runs.
Thing interviews ~45 min · pairs · more-than-human method (Reddy et al., CHI '21)	STRUCTURE Introduce one <i>what if</i>. One person speaks <i>as the robot</i>, answering on its behalf; a partner interviews it about its world, routines, relations, and what it refuses. Swap roles; optionally prime with a photo from the robot's viewpoint.	WHAT TO CAPTURE Direct quotes in the robot's voice; the worldview and relations that surface; what it values or refuses — and the desirable future implied.
Drawing ~45 min · individuals, then share · paper + pens	STRUCTURE Introduce the <i>what if</i>. Fifteen minutes of individual sketching (the robot, the moment, the place). Round-robin share. Cluster ideas.	WHAT TO CAPTURE One to three representative sketches with brief captions. The cluster of ideas the group recognised in common.
Speculative fictions ~60–90 min · individuals or pairs · in <i>writing</i> (a short essay or vignette) or in <i>art</i> (a painting or drawing)	STRUCTURE Introduce one <i>what if</i>. Brief world-building together (who, where, when). Each participant then writes a short speculative vignette <i>or</i> makes one finished image of a scene from that future. Share — read aloud, or exhibit and discuss.	WHAT TO CAPTURE The text or artwork itself (scan or photograph it); a title; one or two sentences naming the desirable future it embodies.
Scene-building ~45 min · small groups · Lego bricks, blocks, or found objects	STRUCTURE Introduce one <i>what if</i>. Each group builds a small physical scene — a single moment from that future — with bricks, blocks, or found objects. Walk the room: each group narrates its scene. Rebuild one element and see what changes.	WHAT TO CAPTURE A photograph of the build; a title; one or two sentences naming the desirable future it embodies.
Brainstorming ~30 min · small group · post-its or notebook	STRUCTURE Three minutes of silent ideation. Round-robin share. Cluster on the wall or page. Vote on the two ideas the group wants to live in.	WHAT TO CAPTURE The top two or three desirable futures with the rationale the group gave for each.
Interviews ~30 min per pair · one-on-one or pairs	STRUCTURE Introduce the <i>what if</i>. Open-ended questions about the person's life, then about how a robot might fit (if at all). Record answers carefully.	WHAT TO CAPTURE One to three direct quotes; the recurring concerns or hopes across interviews; the desirable future each person sketched out in their own words.

DATE	LOCATION	RESEARCHER	TARGET GROUP	FORMAT	PARTICIPANTS
				role-play, drawing, brainstorming, interview...	

What if... _____

TITLE OF THIS DESIRABLE FUTURE

SHORT DESCRIPTION

IMAGE

Sketch directly, photograph, or attach separately and reference here.

A drawing, a diagram, a photo of the workshop output — anything that helps the future feel concrete.

01 What *future* does this imagine? (Not the robot — the life around it.)

02 The robot's *role, shape, and place* in that future.

03 What does this robot *refuse* — or simply not do?

04 Why is this future *desirable*?

Template — adapt before use. Replace every *[bracketed]* field with your own details, and align this sheet with your institution's ethics process and local law. A starting point, not legal advice.

Participant Information Sheet

Desirable Futures with Robots — a distributed workshop series · Workshop: *[title / location]* · Facilitator: *[name], [institution]* · Contact: *[email]*

WHAT IS THIS?

You are invited to take part in a short creative workshop imagining *desirable futures with robots* — the kinds of robots, if any, that people would actually want in their lives. We collect the ideas, stories, and images produced. Taking part is entirely your choice.

WHAT WILL HAPPEN?

The session lasts about *[duration]*. You will take part in a *[role-play / drawing / interview / scene-building / ...]* activity. **Photographs are normally taken of the material produced** — drawings, models, built scenes, written pieces. With your consent, the session may also be **audio- and/or video-recorded**, and photographs may be taken of the activity and the people in it.

DO I HAVE TO TAKE PART?

No. Participation is voluntary. You may decline any question or activity, take a break, or stop at any time — without giving a reason and without consequence. You may withdraw your data up until *[the point at which it is anonymised — e.g. the end of the session]*, after which it can no longer be identified and removed.

HOW IS MY DATA USED AND PROTECTED?

Recordings, photographs, and notes are seen only by the workshop team and held securely (*[where / how]*), under the lawful basis of your **consent**. **Raw recordings are never shared or published**. Only **anonymised, consolidated results** — themes, summaries, aggregated insights — are shared.

The work produced in the session — drawings, written pieces, report forms, and **photographs of any models, built scenes, or objects you make** — forms a shared **corpus of co-created imaginaries**. Once any personal identifiers are removed (for example, a name written on a drawing), this corpus is shared as part of the workshop's outcome under an **open-access licence** (*[e.g. CC BY-SA 4.0]*), so others can read, learn from, and build on it.

Photographs and video that *show you* are different. Only if you give explicit consent will **images showing you** appear in reports, talks, publications, or online — and you can take part fully without agreeing to this.

YOUR RIGHTS

You may ask to access, correct, or erase your data, or withdraw your consent, by contacting *[facilitator / data controller]*. Data is retained until *[retention period]*, then deleted. Full detail is on the Data Management Plan (page 8).

QUESTIONS OR CONCERNS

Contact the facilitator at *[email]*. If you have concerns about how this workshop was run, contact *[local ethics committee / data protection officer]*.

Template — adapt before use. Pair this with the information sheet (page 6). The minors / guardian panel is optional — keep it only for workshops with participants under *[18]*.

Participant Consent Form

Desirable Futures with Robots · Workshop: *[title / location]* · Date: *[date]*

PLEASE INITIAL EACH BOX

☐

I have read and understood the information sheet and have had the chance to ask questions.

☐

I understand my participation is voluntary and that I may withdraw at any time, without giving a reason, up until my data is anonymised.

☐

I agree to take part in the workshop activity.

☐

I understand the session may be **audio- and/or video-recorded**, and that **photographs** may be taken.

☐

I understand that **raw recordings will not be shared**, and that only **anonymised, consolidated results** will be published.

☐

I agree that the **material I produce** — drawings, writings, and photographs of any models or built scenes — may be shared, with personal identifiers removed, in the **open-access corpus** of workshop outcomes.

OPTIONAL — IMAGES SHOWING YOU (TICK YOUR CHOICE)

I agree that **photographs or short video excerpts that show me** may be used in publications, presentations, and online.

☐

YES

☐

NO

NAME (BLOCK CAPITALS)

SIGNATURE

DATE

FACILITATOR NAME & SIGNATURE

For participants under [18] — parental / guardian authorisation

The activity and this form have been explained to the child in terms they can understand, and they are happy to take part. A parent or legal guardian must co-sign below.

CHILD'S NAME

PARENT / GUARDIAN NAME

PARENT / GUARDIAN SIGNATURE

DATE

Template — adapt before use. Complete one plan per workshop (or per series, if your set-up is identical). Fill every *[bracketed]* field and check it against your institution's policy and the GDPR — or your local equivalent.

Data Management Plan

Desirable Futures with Robots · Workshop: *[title / location]* · Facilitator: *[name / institution]*

DATA COLLECTED	Varies by methodology, but typically: audio recordings, video recordings, photographs, participant drawings or built artefacts, written notes, and completed report forms. <i>[adjust to your activity]</i>
PERSONAL DATA	Faces and voices in recordings; names and signatures on consent forms; anything personal a participant chooses to disclose. No special-category data is sought. <i>[note any exceptions]</i>
LAWFUL BASIS	Participant consent — and parental / guardian consent for minors — freely given and withdrawable.
CONTROLLER	<i>[institution / data controller]</i> · Contact / DPO: <i>[name, email]</i>
STORAGE & SECURITY	Held on <i>[encrypted institutional storage]</i> ; access limited to the named workshop team. Consent forms stored separately from recordings.
SHARING	Raw recordings (audio / video) are not shared. Photographs of the material produced — drawings, models, built scenes — are shared as workshop outcomes once personal identifiers are removed. Images that show participants are shared only with their explicit consent. Otherwise only anonymised, consolidated results are shared.
OPEN-ACCESS CORPUS	The final corpus of co-created imaginaries — drawings, writings, report forms, and photographs of produced models or scenes, all with personal identifiers removed — is published under an open-access licence (<i>[e.g. CC BY-SA 4.0]</i>) for reuse.
ANONYMISATION	Names replaced with codes; identifying details removed; faces blurred unless image-sharing consent was given. <i>[method]</i>
RETENTION	Raw data kept until <i>[date / period]</i> , then securely deleted. Anonymised, consolidated results may be retained indefinitely.
PARTICIPANT RIGHTS	Access, rectification, erasure, and withdrawal of consent — by contacting the controller above, up until anonymisation.